

Power Tracker: US Markets Tightening Into Summer, Only Marginally Eased by Coal Power Policy

- **Regional divergence in focus as summer starts.** June 1 marks the rollover of 1-month forward contracts across regional power markets from trading June contracts to trading July contracts. This transition reveals market expectations on peak summer power market tightness, along with generation fuel costs. We see contrasting trends between PJM (Mid-Atlantic) and ERCOT (Texas) power markets:
 - **PJM (Mid-Atlantic):** The power price increased significantly more during this year's May-to-June rollover compared to the historical average in the past decade, both in terms of the absolute price level (+28 USD/MWh in 2026 vs +15 USD/MWh in 2016–2025) and the percentage change (+44% vs +30%, [Exhibit 1](#)), despite prices of marginal generation fuels, natural gas and coal, increasing much less. This larger price increase into the summer, combined with its upward trend since 2020 ([Exhibit 1](#)), is consistent with our view of a tightening power market in the region: PJM hosts 39% of US data center power demand capacity, where power demand growth has continued to outpace power supply growth.
 - **ERCOT (Texas):** While the ERCOT market also experienced its typical seasonal price increase rolling over into June, the absolute price rise of \$24/MWh was smaller than the previous decade's average of \$30/MWh and the percentage increase was just above the historical average (61% versus 56%, [Exhibit 1](#)). In addition, the price levels in both May and June have been lower than in 2024/2025, driven by the recent softening in the Texas market¹.
 - **Regional divergence:** This rollover contrast between these two regional markets is consistent with our regional divergence view that ERCOT has entered a softening path since late-2025 with substantial expansion in power supply, while we expect PJM to remain critically tight in the next few years.
- **We expect federal support for coal power to offer marginal relief.** To alleviate power market tightness, the US administration refreshed its support for coal power following President Trump's advocacy for "Beautiful Clean Coal Power" earlier this year. Earlier this month, the president announced a new plan to allocate nearly \$700 million to support coal power (and coal exports), mainly by

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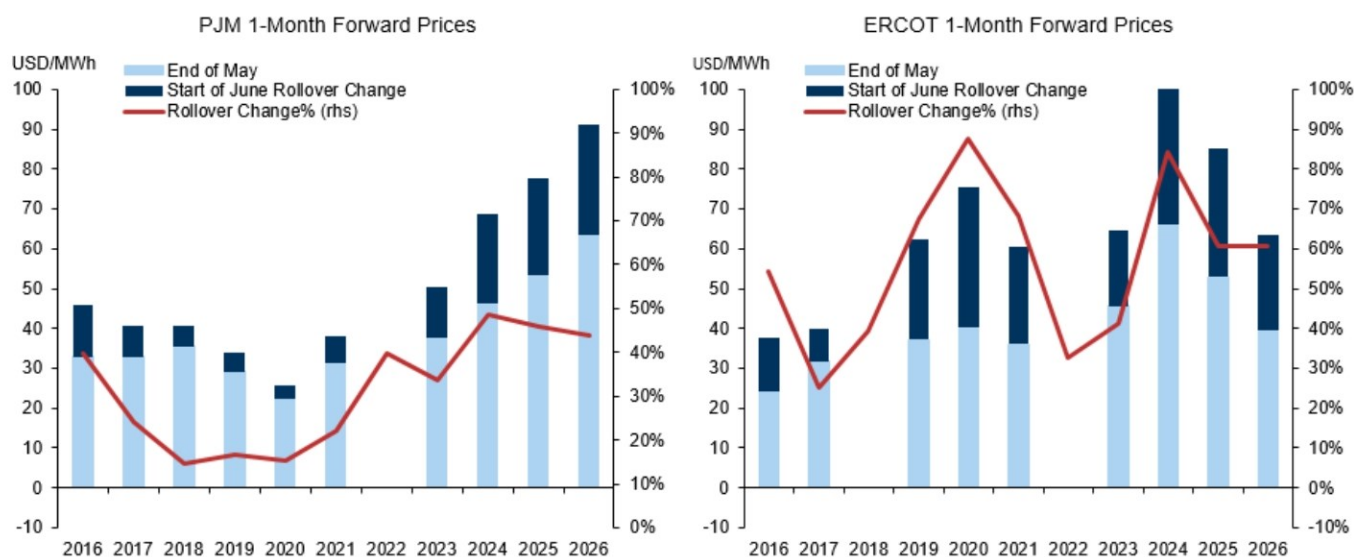
¹ The magnitude of these price increases is not directly comparable to PJM due to different market structures.

financing delaying/canceling scheduled coal power retirements. While we expect this plan to effectively add incremental power supply relative to previous schedules, along with emergency orders of US Department of Energy (DOE) that direct coal power plants to remain online, we believe the overall impact on resolving market tightness could be marginal in 2026-2028 and after 2028 for the following reasons:

- **Increasing difficulties for more retirement delays:** A significant amount of scheduled coal retirements have already been delayed in the past year after the first DOE emergency order in May 2025, which pushed 2025/2026 retirements out to 2026-2029 (Exhibit 2). Remaining scheduled retirements could be subject to physical/financial constraints: already delayed retirements may face a higher bar to be delayed again and most coal plants are old, both lacking extensive maintenance given the original retirement schedules which could drive the cumulative maintenance costs beyond the scope of the \$700-million fund.
- **Longer-term policy uncertainty:** Coal power plants and coal producers continue to face regulatory and policy uncertainty beyond 2028, which disincentivizes significant capex to upgrade or even expand capacity. One example is the coal power retirement delays in the TVA (Tennessee) power market, where a total of 4.1 GW coal power generation capacity, all originally scheduled for retirement by the end of 2028, has been delayed, while retirement schedules beyond that window remain unchanged.

Featured Charts

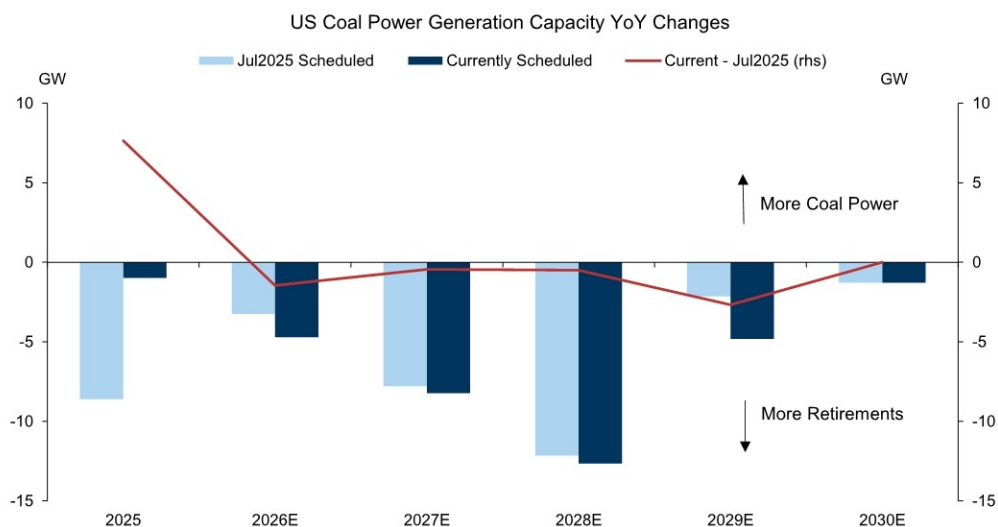
Exhibit 1: The rollover of power forward contracts show a higher-than-average June price level and May-to-June price increase in PJM vs lower-than-average in ERCOT



Prices of PJM in 2022 and of ERCOT in 2018 and 2022 are above 100 \$/MWh and not shown in the charts, but are counted in historical average calculations.

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 2: Coal retirement delays since 2025 have effectively increased power supply in the next few years, but are more constrained going forward



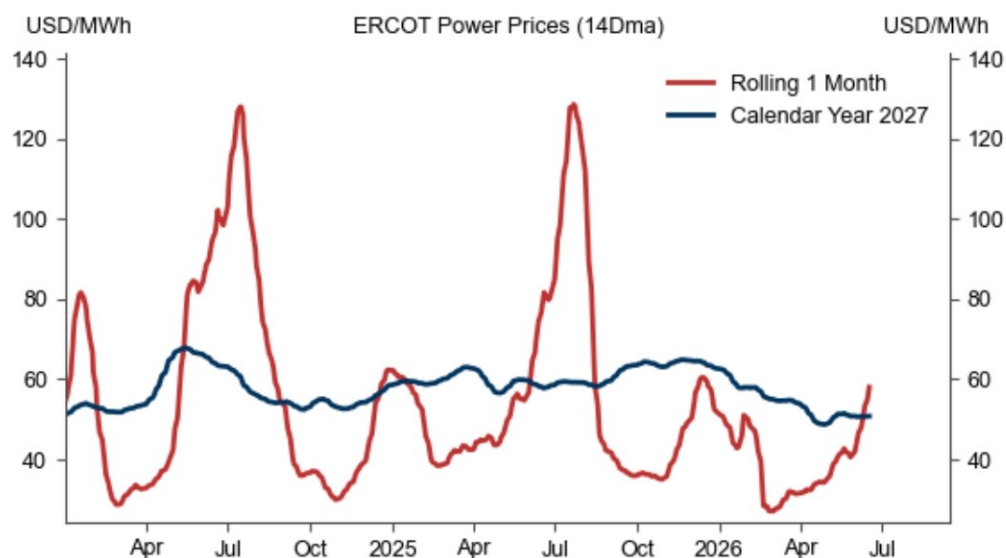
Based on EIA generator schedules released in late May 2026, which do not include some recent announcements/DOE orders that adjust the timeline of coal power plants' retirements

Source: EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Prices

Exhibit 3: ERCOT (Texas) early summer power price remains weak yoy, remaining below 60 USD/MWh

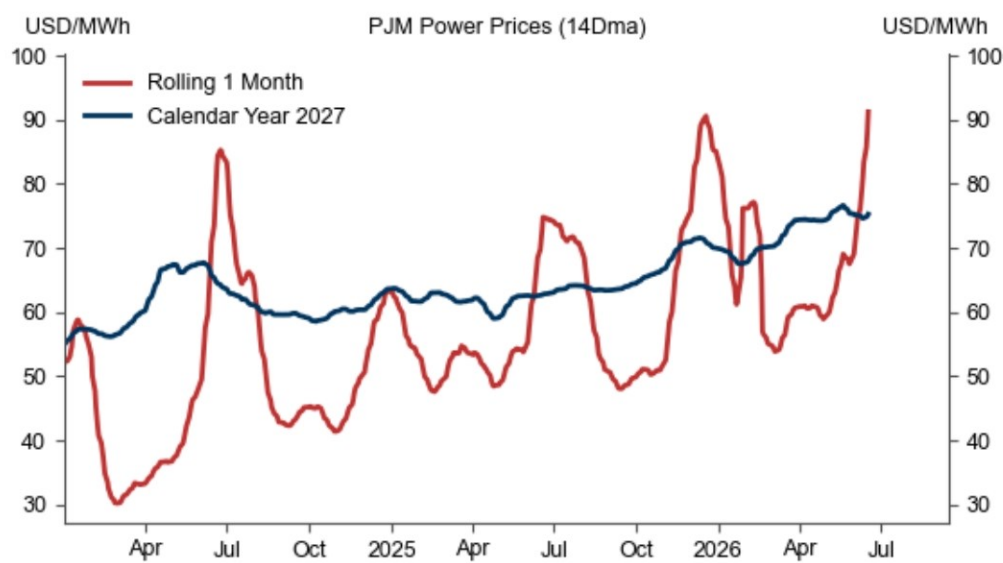
ERCOT North 345kV Hub peak load prices



Source: Bloomberg

Exhibit 4: Power prices in PJM (Mid-Atlantic) rally into the 90 USD/MWh range with the forward contract rollover

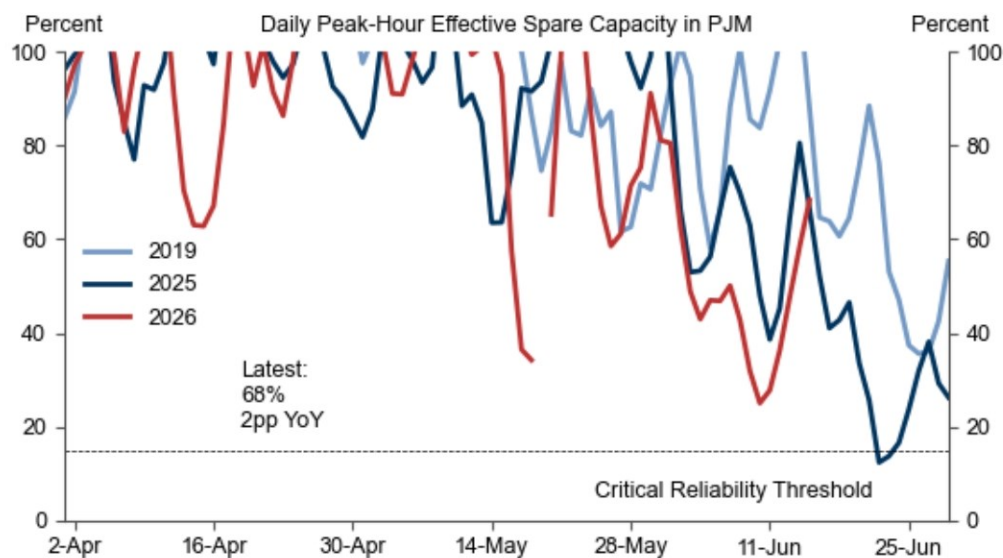
PJM western hub peak power swap prices



Source: Bloomberg

Market Tightness

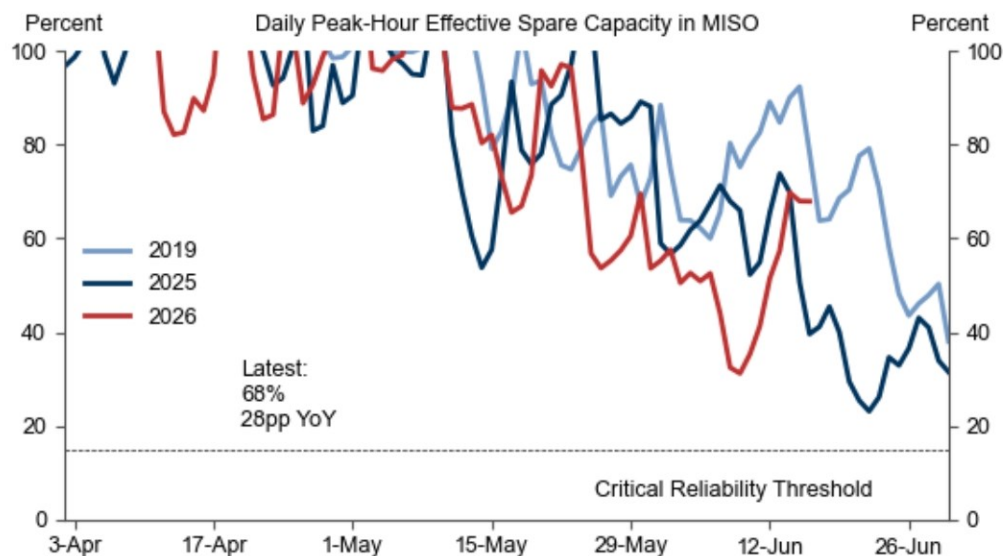
Exhibit 5: The PJM (Mid-Atlantic) power market was tightened by heatwaves into June



Effective spare capacity for a day is calculated using daily peak-hour power demand and effective power generation capacity in the month in a given power market, indicating critical tightness if below 15%. Not showing in the chart if above 100% (a very soft market).

Source: Regional power ISOs and RTOs, EIA, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

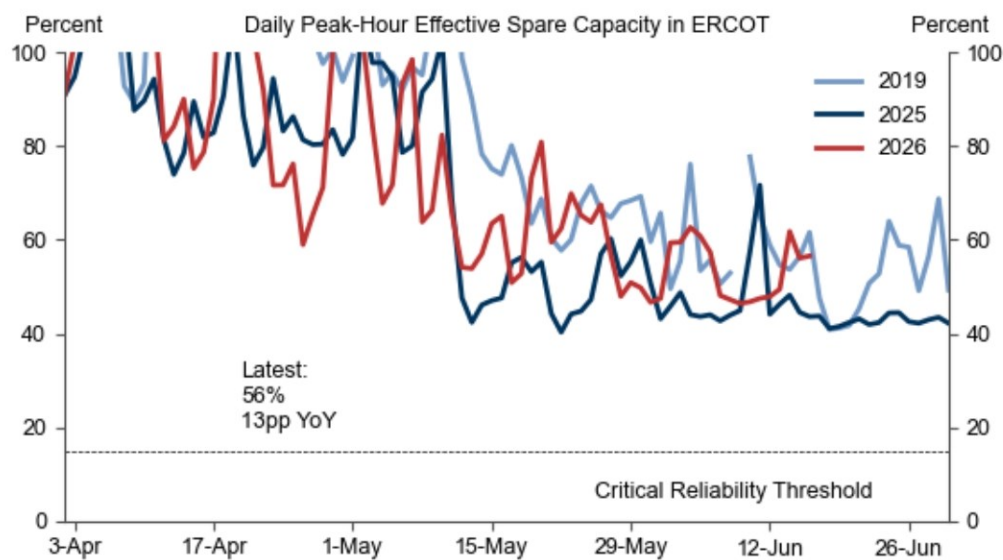
Exhibit 6: The MISO (Mid-Continental) power market also turned tighter into June before softening this week



Effective spare capacity for a day is calculated using daily peak-hour power demand and effective power generation capacity in the month in a given power market, indicating critical tightness if below 15%. Not showing in the chart if above 100% (a very soft market).

Source: Regional power ISOs and RTOs, EIA, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 7: The ERCOT (Texas) power market maintained a soft balance with mild weather



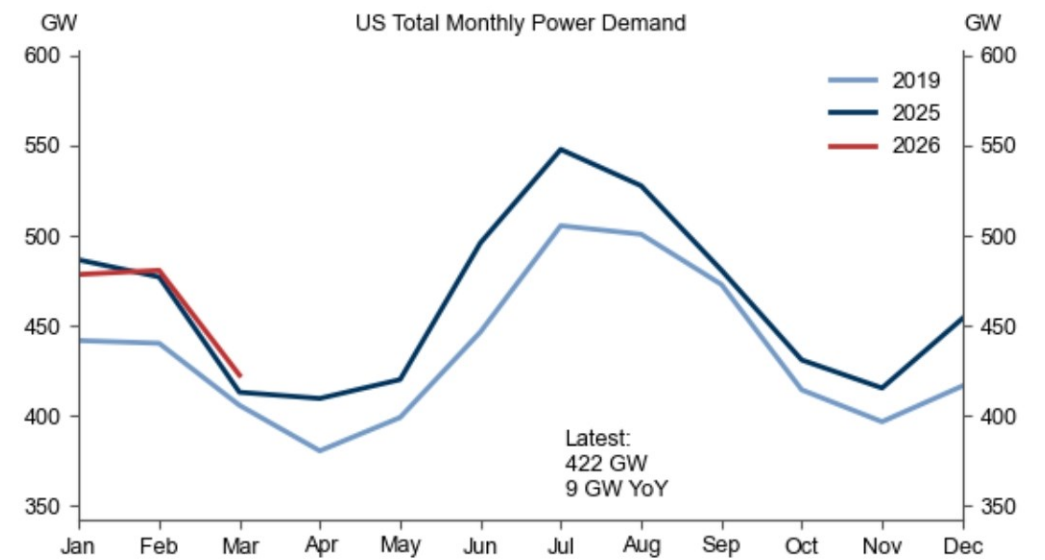
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Source: Regional power ISOs and RTOs, EIA, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Demand

Aggregate Power Demand

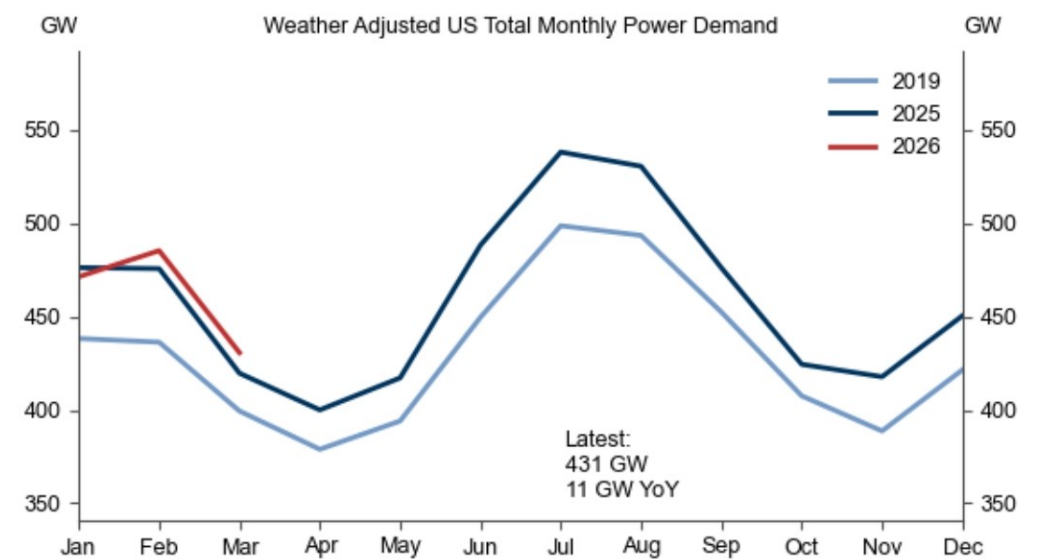
Exhibit 8: Total US yoy power demand growth strengthens to 2.3% in March, but still below the annual yoy growth rate of 2.4% in 2025



Not weather adjusted

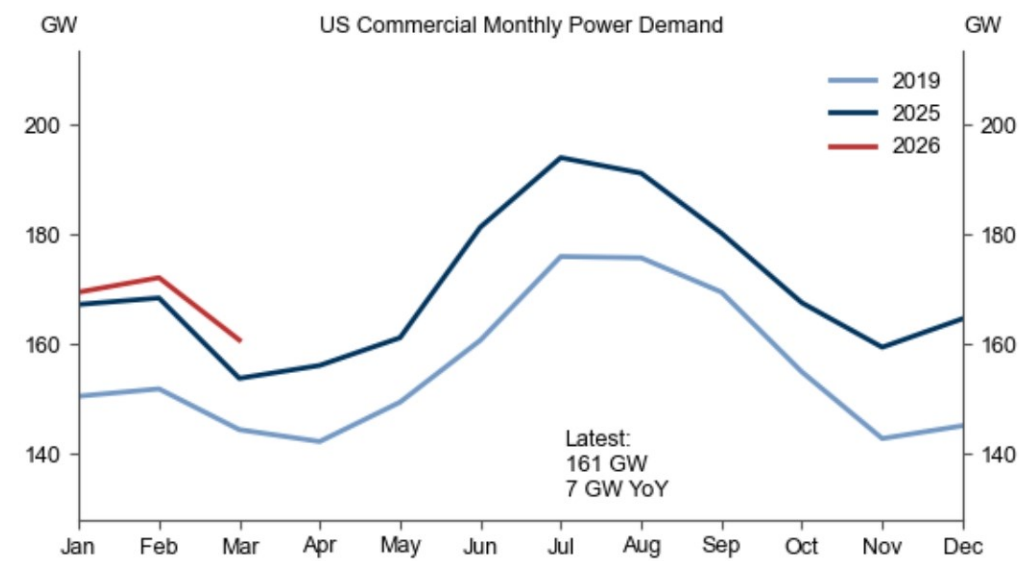
Source: EIA, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 9: After weather adjustment, US total power demand growth in Jan-Mar2026 was 1.2%, also below last year's growth



Source: EIA, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

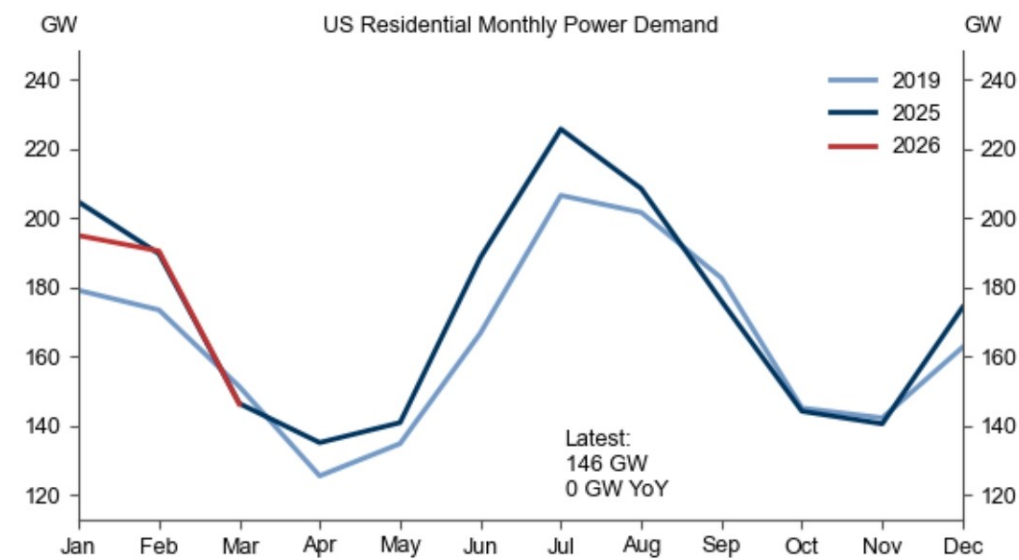
Exhibit 10: The commercial sector continues to be the strongest sector in power demand growth in Jan-Mar2026 with a 2.7% yoy growth rate



Not weather adjusted

Source: EIA, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

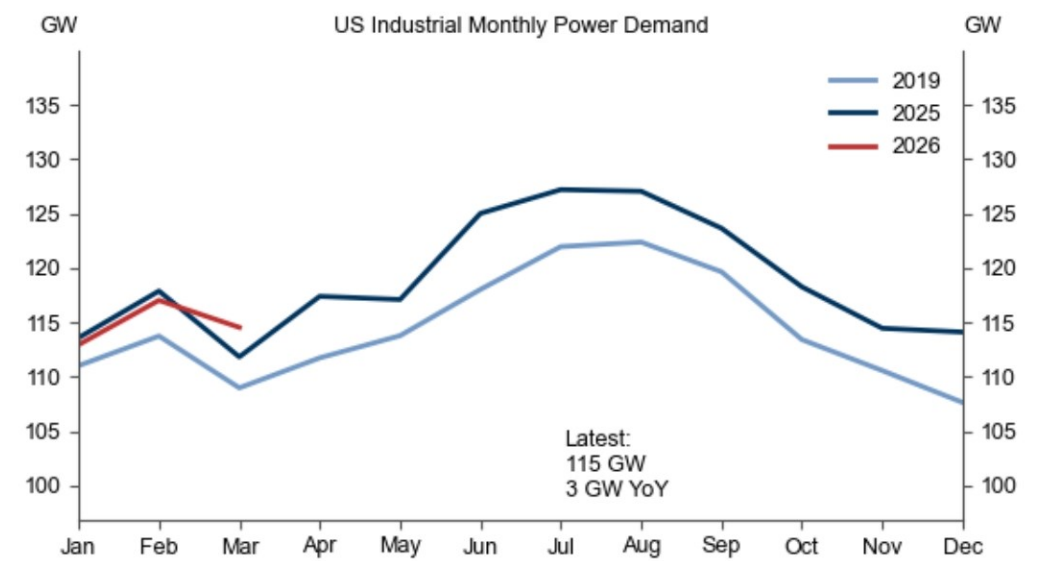
Exhibit 11: After a weak start of the year in Jan2026, US residential power demand remained flattish yoy in Feb-Mar



Not weather adjusted

Source: EIA, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

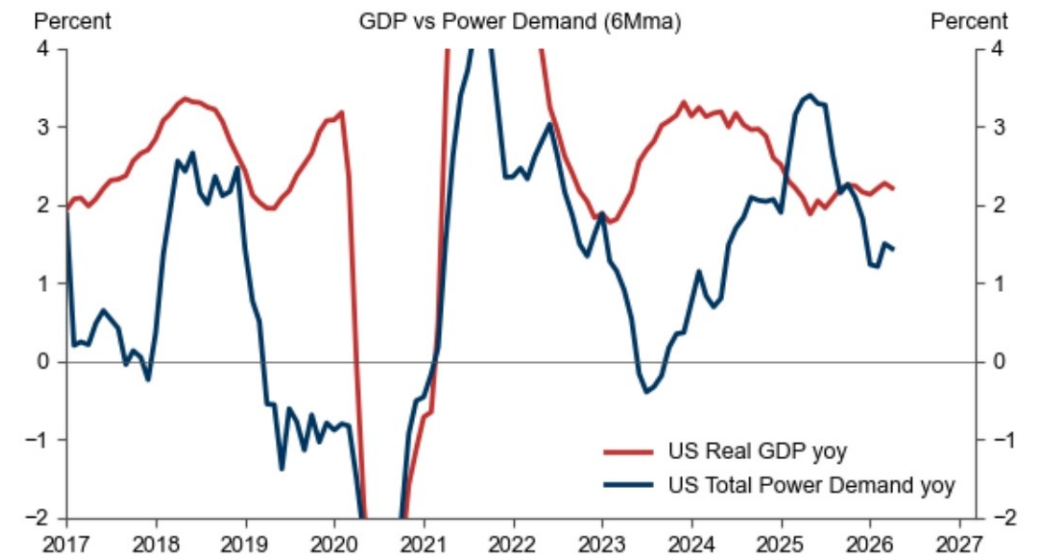
Exhibit 12: Industrial power demand strengthened into March after Jan-Feb2026 yoy weakness



Not weather adjusted

Source: EIA, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 13: US power demand growth remained below US GDP growth through Apr2026
Weather-adjusted US total power demand (including small-scale solar power use) and US real GDP yoy, monthly

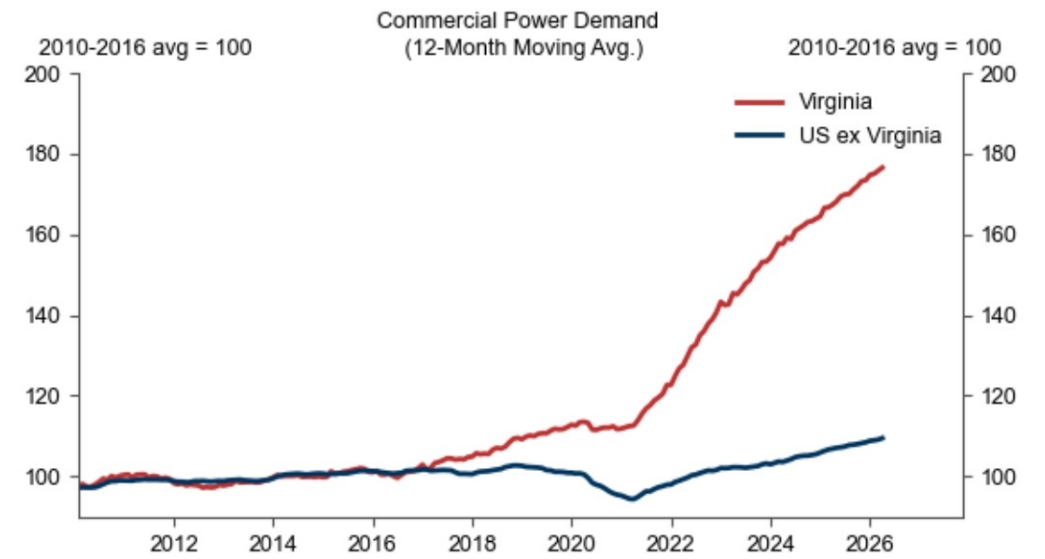


To avoid underestimating power demand, we include all small-scale solar power generation in US total power demand

Source: EIA, Bloomberg, Haver, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Data Center Power Demand

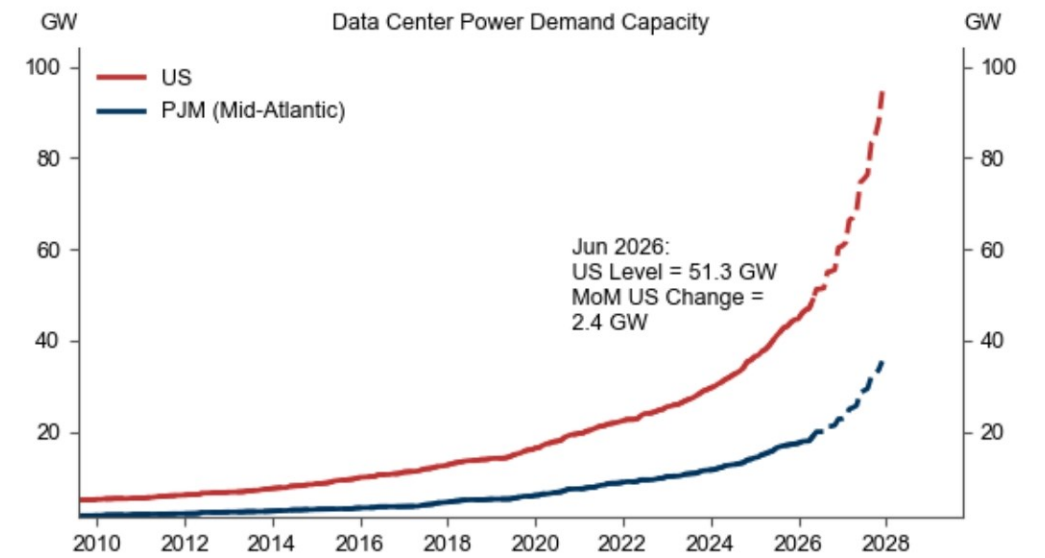
Exhibit 14: Estimated data center power demand in Virginia continued to edge higher



Not weather adjusted

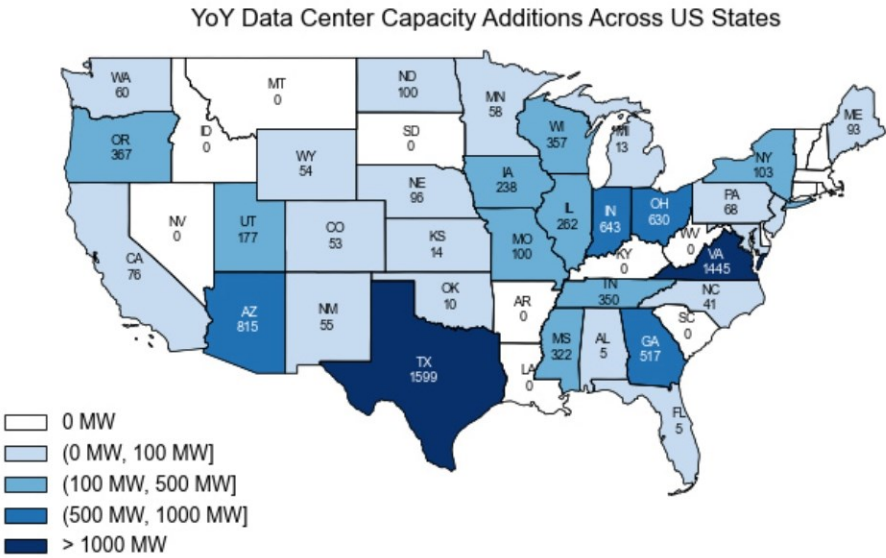
Source: Haver, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 15: US data center capacity continued to grow, which we expect to accelerate in June and also in 2H2026



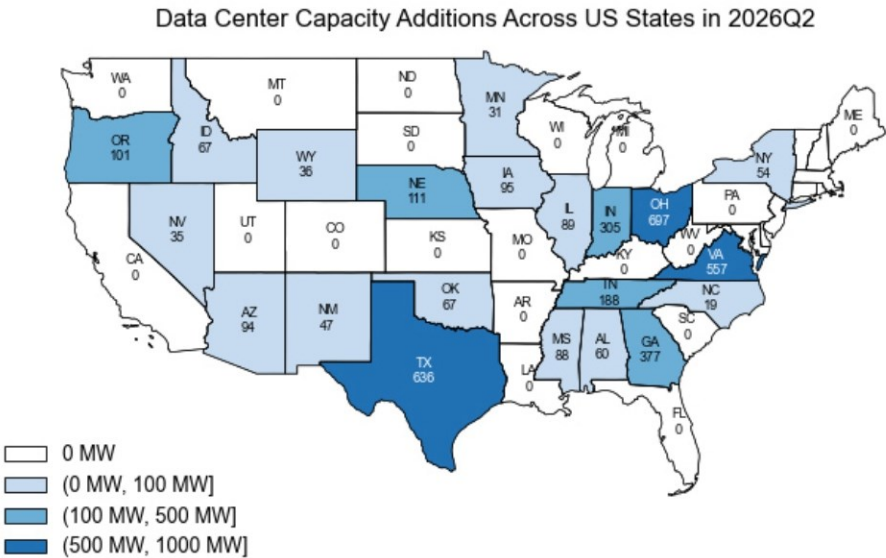
Source: Aterio, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 16: Texas and Virginia led data center expansions in the past year, along with Arizona, Indiana, Ohio and Georgia



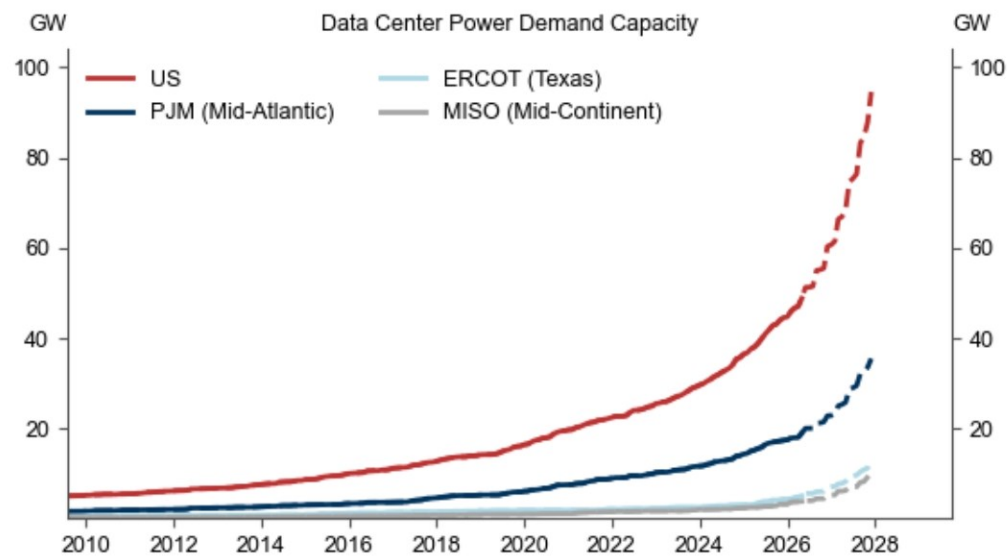
Source: Aterio, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 17: Ohio, Texas, and Virginia are leading data center development in 2026Q2



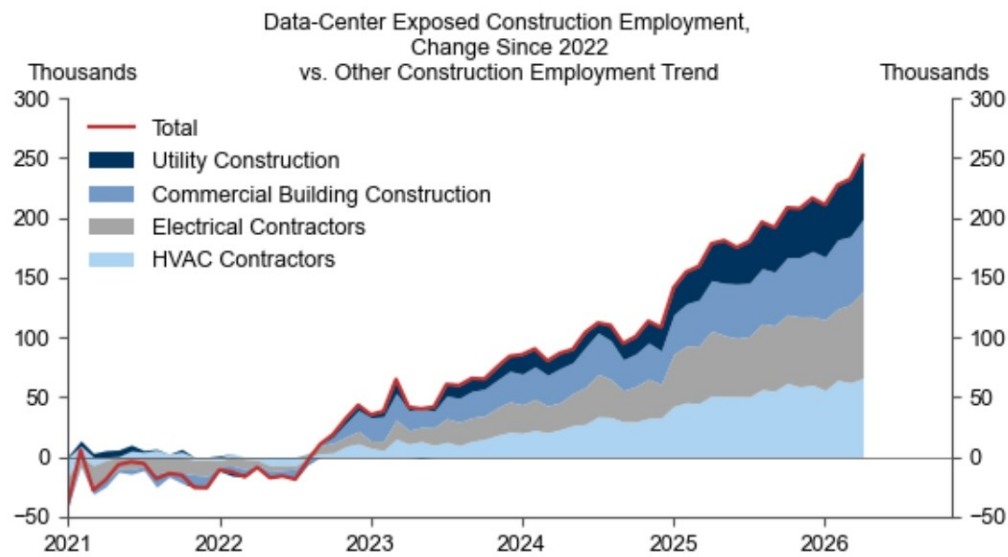
Source: Aterio, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 18: We expect significant data center growth acceleration in both the US national and key regional power markets in 2026/27



Source: Aterio, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

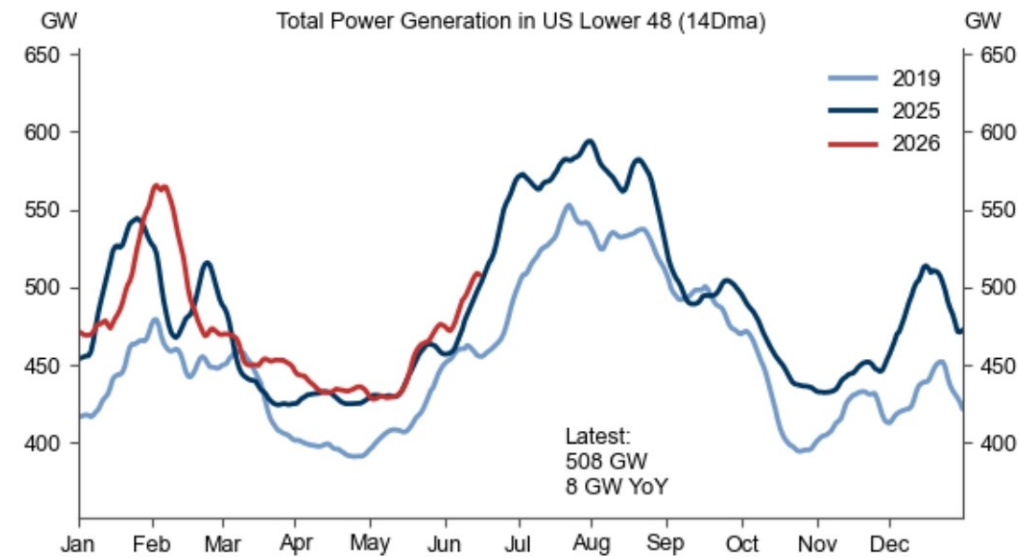
Exhibit 19: Construction employment related to US data center expansion continued its growing trend



Source: Haver, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Generation and Stack

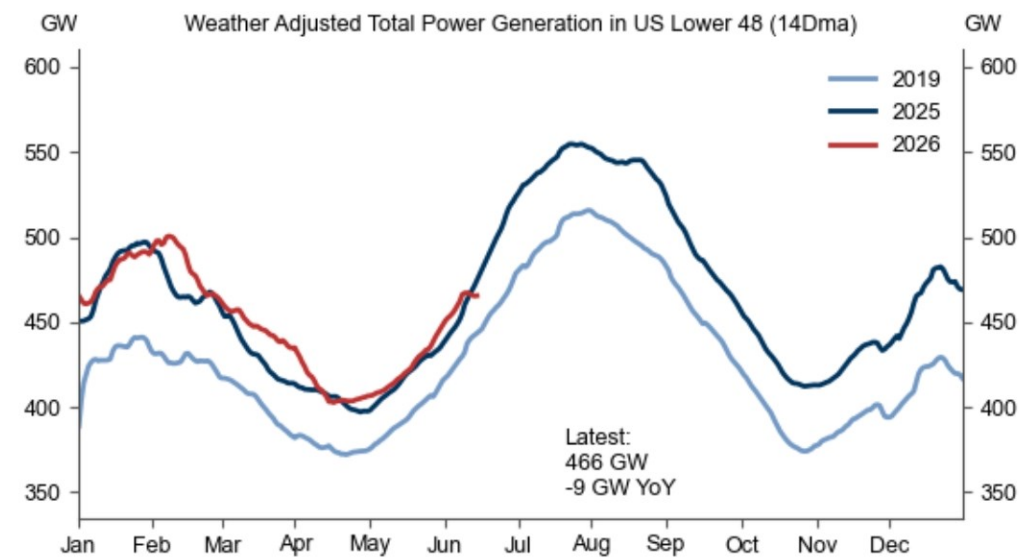
Exhibit 20: US total power generation stayed in line in most of May before gaining strength into early-summer



Not weather adjusted

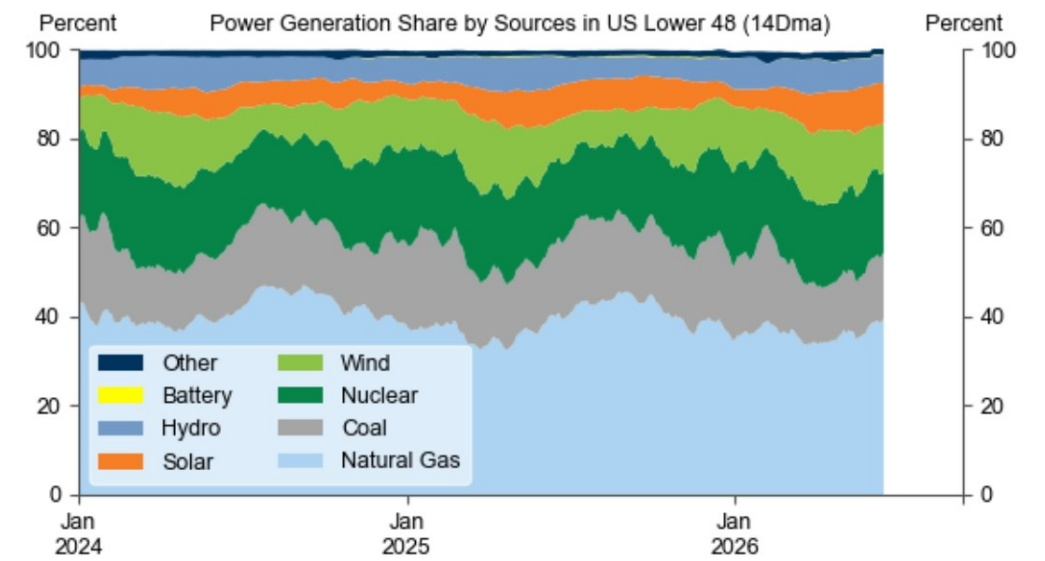
Source: EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 21: After adjusting for weather, US total power generation holds in line with early-summer year-ago levels



Source: EIA, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

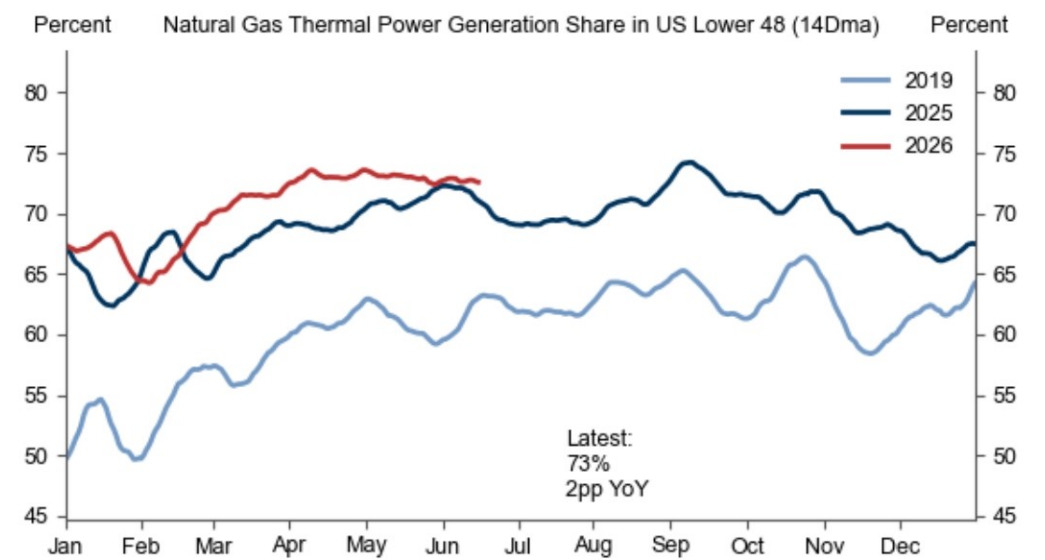
Exhibit 22: The thermal (natural gas and coal) share in US power supply continues to increase from mid-April given yoy weaker hydro and nuclear



Not weather adjusted

Source: EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

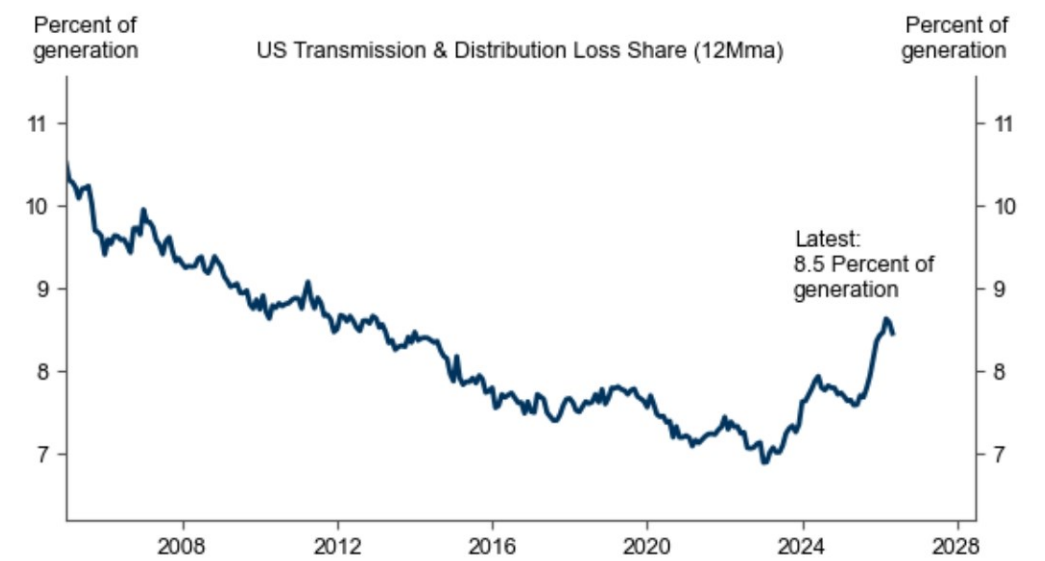
Exhibit 23: Within thermal power generation, the natural gas share remained higher yoy given price competitiveness



Not weather adjusted

Source: EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 24: US power transmission and distribution losses continued to increase into 2026, though marginally lower in Apr/May

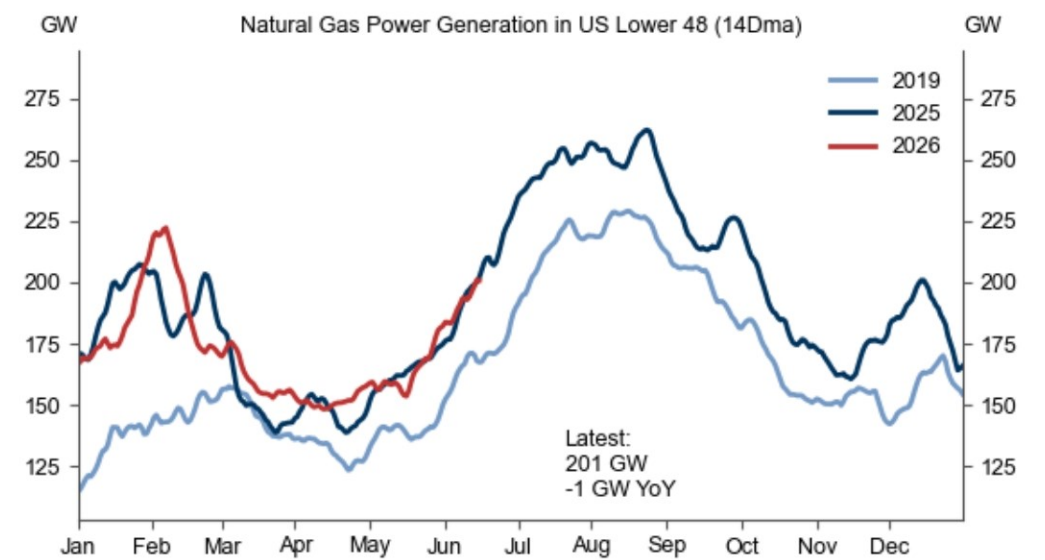


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Source: EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Generation by Fuels

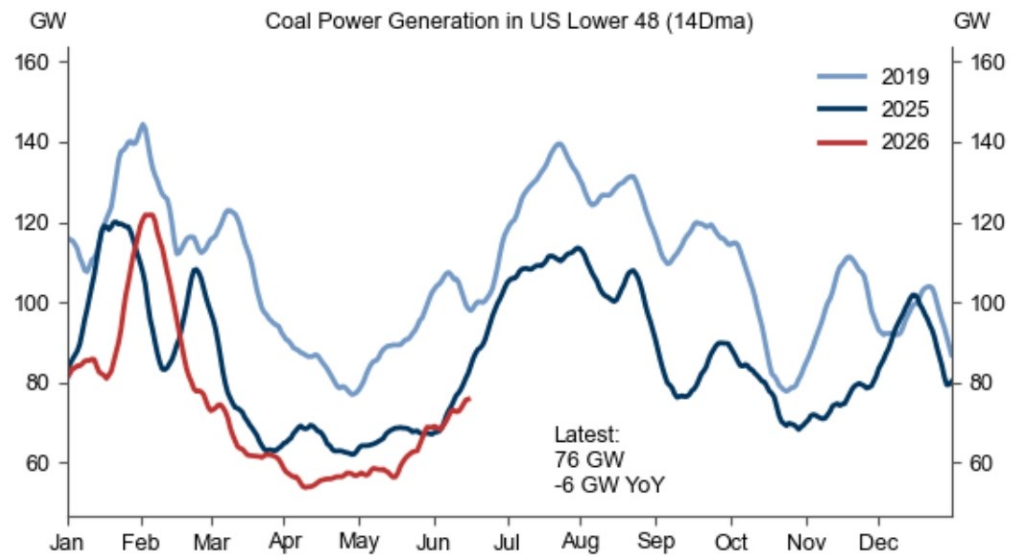
Exhibit 25: YoY growth in natural gas-fired generation has moved sequentially lower June-to-date vs March and April but remains positive



Not weather adjusted

Source: EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

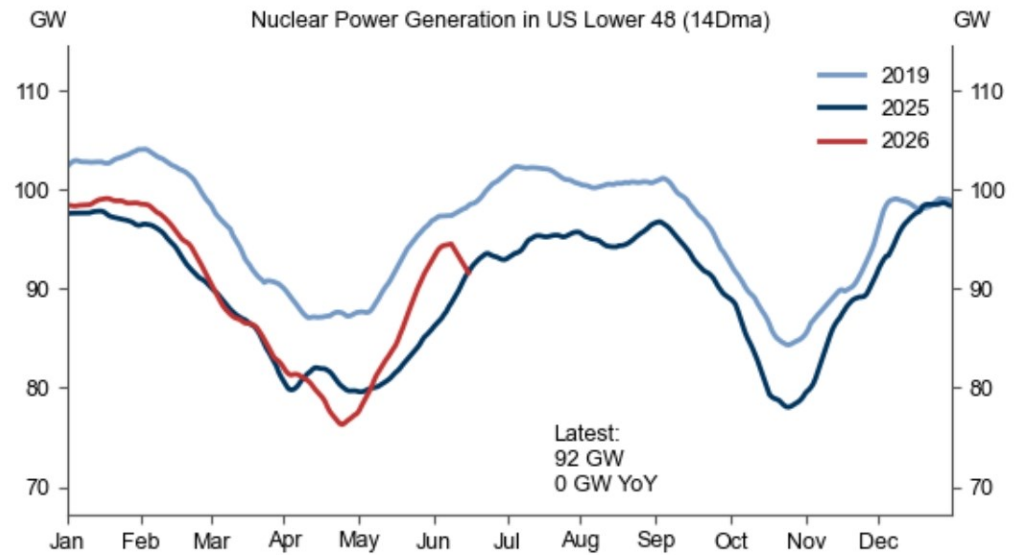
Exhibit 26: Higher gas competitiveness keeps coal power generation lower yoy most of the time from mid-Feb to Jun



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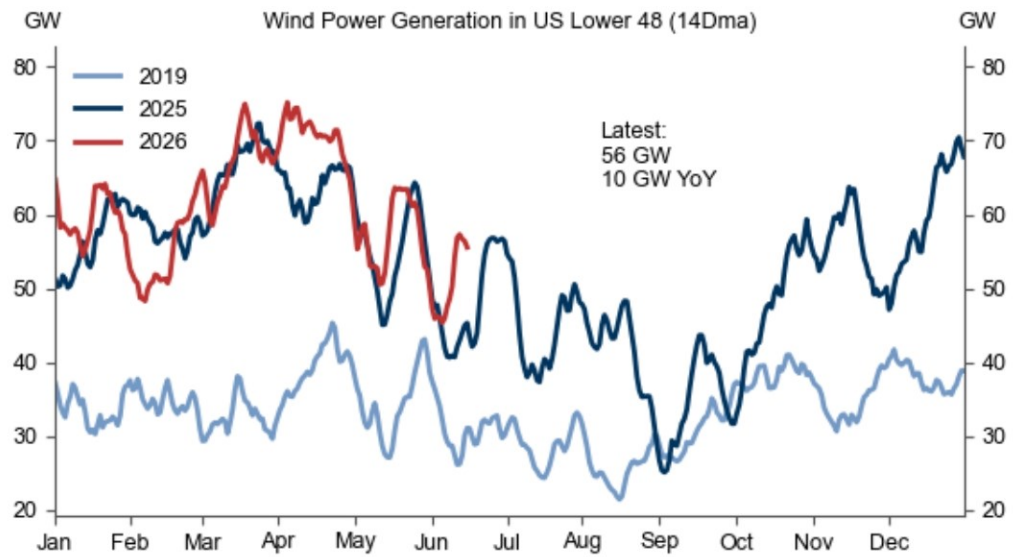
Source: EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 27: Nuclear power generation turns higher yoy into May and June following April maintenance



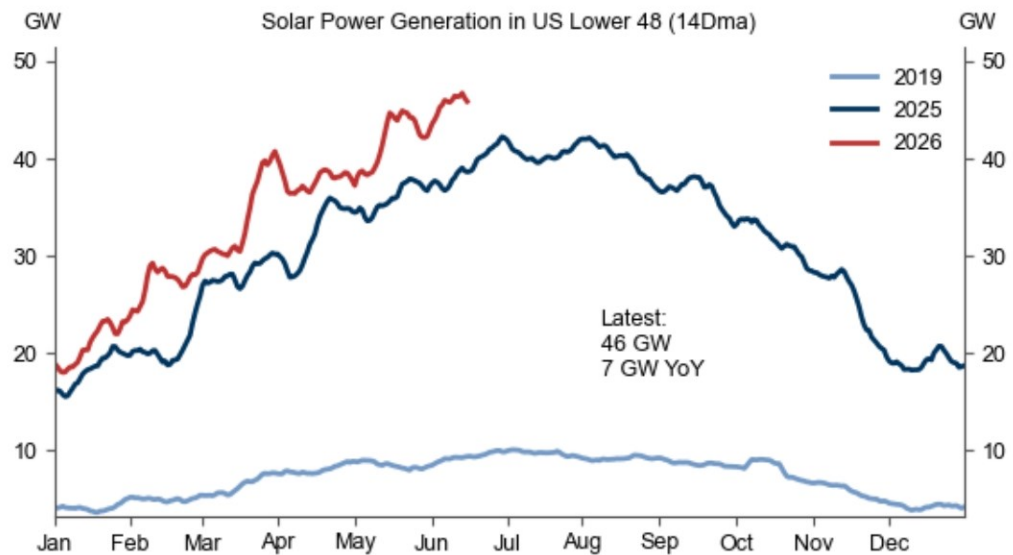
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Source: EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 28: Wind generation moves higher yoy in May and June

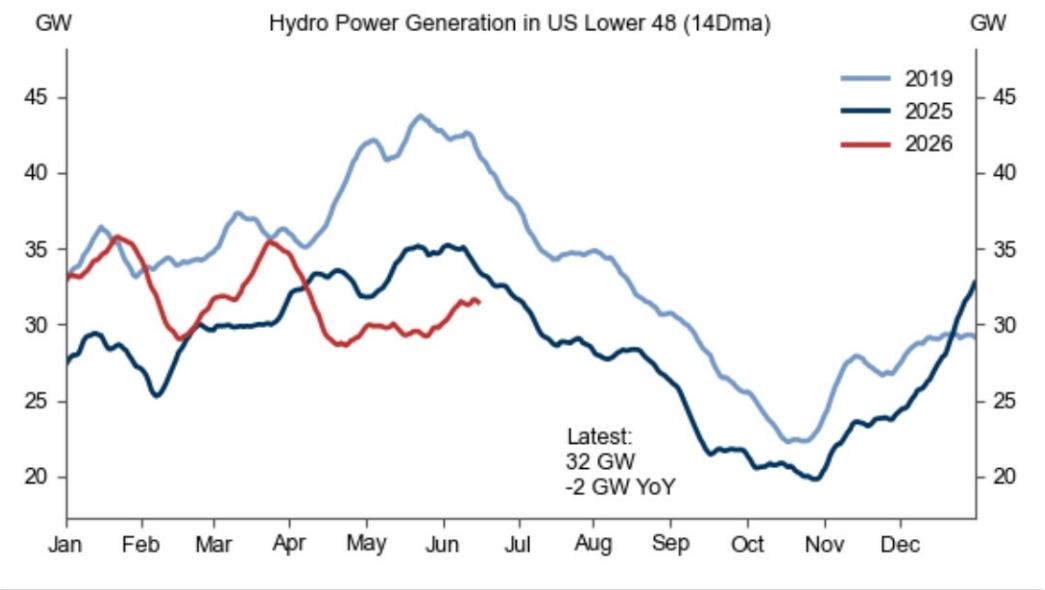
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Source: EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 29: Solar generation has continued to seasonally ramp up, driven by yoy capacity additions of over 30 GW

Source: EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 30: Hydro power generation remains weak yoy due to droughts in more than half of the country



Source: EIA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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Reg AC

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